
Some Changes in the Matrilineal Family System among the Chewa of Malawi since the Nineteenth Century

Author(s): Kings M. Phiri

Source: *The Journal of African History*, Vol. 24, No. 2, The History of the Family in Africa (1983), pp. 257-274

Published by: [Cambridge University Press](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/181644>

Accessed: 12/11/2013 07:36

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



Cambridge University Press is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *The Journal of African History*.

<http://www.jstor.org>

SOME CHANGES IN THE MATRILINEAL FAMILY SYSTEM AMONG THE CHEWA OF MALAWI SINCE THE NINETEENTH CENTURY

BY KINGS M. PHIRI

THIS article examines the nature of the family in a matrilineal context and its adaptation to historical change, using the Chewa of central Malawi as an example.¹ The mid-nineteenth century is taken as a point of departure, due to the availability from that time onwards of both written and oral sources. An attempt is made to delineate changes in traditional family structure and relationships which resulted from a variety of developments within and outside Chewa society. This subject poses severe methodological problems. In the pre-colonial period, polities and families in central Africa were in a state of flux on account of constant migration and warfare, while the absence of literacy precluded contemporary records. There are, indeed, modern studies of social structure, including kinship and marriage, among the Chewa of Eastern Zambia;² these works explore parallels between the Chewa and other peoples but lack a specifically historical dimension.³

It is often supposed that among both the Chewa and their southeastern neighbours, the Yao, uxori-locality (the husband living with his wife's relations) and the avunculate (the exercise of domestic authority by the wife's brother) were more firmly entrenched than among other peoples of the matrilineal belt of central Africa.⁴ In Dedza district, central Malawi, however, Mair found that matriliney had undergone several fundamental changes, so that neither uxori-locality nor the avunculate could be assumed to be central features of Chewa family life.⁵ It also seemed to Mair that most of the changes in question tended towards the accommodation of patriliney, or certain aspects of it. This is a point to which we shall return.

As elsewhere in Africa, matriliney among the Chewa is a complex of several variables, including the nature of marriage, residence during marriage, the exercise of domestic authority and the control or custody of children. In all

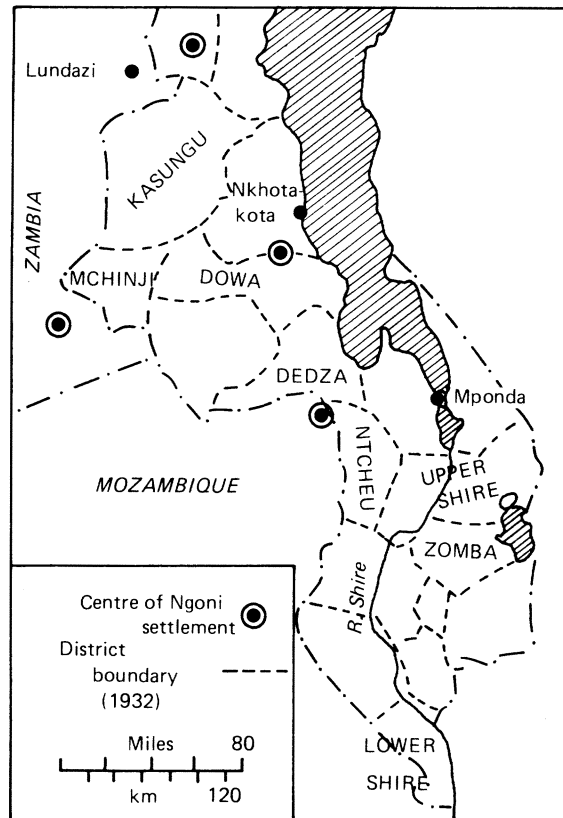
¹ The Chewa, who also extend into eastern Zambia, are the largest ethnic group in Malawi. There were reckoned to be 885,000 in 1945, 1,260,000 in 1966 and 1,630,000 in 1977: Nyasaland Government, *Report on the Census of 1945* (Zomba, 1946), 4–8; Guy Atkins, 'The Nyanja-speaking population of Nyasaland and Northern Rhodesia', *African Studies*, ix (1950), 35–9; *Malawi Population Census, 1966: final report* (Zomba, 1966); *Malawi Population Census, 1977: provisional report* (Zomba, 1977).

² M. G. Marwick, an affiliate of the Rhodes-Livingstone Institute, did fieldwork in 1946–7, 1948–9 and 1952–3; cf. his *Sorcery in its Social Setting: a Study of the Northern Rhodesia Chewa* (Manchester, 1965). J. P. Bruwer, a missionary of the Dutch Reformed Church, wrote a thesis on the matrilineal family of the Chewa (M.A. University of Pretoria, 1949).

³ As in A. R. Radcliffe-Brown and Daryll Forde (eds.), *African Systems of Kinship and Marriage* (London, 1950).

⁴ Cf. A. I. Richards, 'Some types of family structure amongst the Central Bantu', *ibid.* 230–6, based on the early work of Marwick and J. C. Mitchell.

⁵ Lucy Mair, 'Marriage and family in the Dedza District of Nyasaland', *J. Royal Anthropological Institute (J.R.A.I.)*, LXXXI (1952), 106.



Central and Southern Malawi.

these respects, changes have taken place since the nineteenth century, even if there have also been elements of stability. The Chewa were affected by the slave trade of the east coast; they also witnessed the intrusion of patrilineal groups, Ngoni from southern Africa and Swahili from the coast. From the 1870s missionaries began to introduce Christian teaching and European techniques of education, and from the 1890s the Chewa were not only subjected to colonial rule but drawn into a capitalist economy.

I

If we look at the Chewa family and lineage system as an ideal construct, it will be noted that it gives considerable weight to what Radcliffe-Brown called the 'mother right', i.e. the right of the mother even in marriage to remain united with her own kinsmen, and to control, with their help, the offspring of her marriage. The mother is supposed to remain united with her brothers and sisters, and together with them to retain rights of possession over the children. Consequently, the father has little control over his wife and

children.⁶ Furthermore, as a consequence of the wife's dependence on her male kinsmen, the system accords a greater role than other family systems to the wife's brother or children's maternal uncle. The wife's brother becomes guardian (*nkhoswe*) to his sister and her offspring, and the sustainer of their social, economic and legal interests. He is, as Bruwer put it, 'their guardian, helper and defender in all matters social and juridical'.⁷ A woman without a *nkhoswe* is virtually a slave and therefore extremely unfortunate. She stands in need of a male kinsman to protect her, to arrange her marriage, and to represent her in her dealings with outsiders. The system also accords greater social or symbolic respect to women than men, as reproducers of the lineage. This is expressed and stressed by the fact that for women, but not for men, the transition from childhood to puberty and puberty to parenthood was marked by elaborate initiation ceremonies, each of which was further enacted in several stages.⁸

Taken together, these features suggest that the Chewa family was seen as an integral part of the wife's rather than the husband's lineage. In other words, the locus of control of the productive as well as reproductive capabilities of the Chewa nuclear family lay within the woman's group. In particular, it lay in the hands of the *ankhoswe* or men on whom the woman was said to depend for social support. This in turn meant that the family was for the most part dependent on the larger social unit to which it was affiliated: the matrilineage, which embraced most of the woman's relatives. In fact, it was the matrilineage that defined the rights and obligations of the individual family or household, gave it its sense of belonging, provided it with both social and material security, and defined its status within the larger community.⁹

Among the Chewa, the matrilineage or *bele* (breast) was viewed as consisting of all those who could trace their descent from a common ancestress. In the traditions of such a group, this founding ancestress or her male guardian was called *tsinde* (the root). Furthermore, in each generation, collateral members were divided along sex lines into two groups: the women constituted the *mbumba* (dependants) while the men acted as *nkhoswe* (guardians). In this way, the dependence of the women on their male kinsmen was emphasized.¹⁰ This description of the Chewa matrilineage, however, would be incomplete without taking into account the institution of marriage, for through it a matrilineage acquired the productive and reproductive services of other lineages.

There are several descriptions of Chewa marriage in its various forms. As far as regular marriages were concerned, it was up to a man to take the

⁶ S. Roberts, 'A comparison of the family law and custom of two matrilineal systems in Nyasaland', *Nyasaland J.*, xvii (1964), 24-5.

⁷ J. P. Bruwer, 'Ankhoswe: the system of guardianship in Chewa matrilineal society', *African Studies*, xiv (1955), 119.

⁸ A. Makumbi, *Maliro ndi Miyambo ya Achewa* (London, 1955), *passim*; R. G. Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa: the Anglican case, 1885-1950' (Ph.D. thesis, University of London, 1974).

⁹ Marwick, *Sorcery*, 111-67; E. A. Alpers, *Ivory and Slaves in east-central Africa* (London, 1975), 28; E. C. Mandala, 'The nature and substance of Mang'anja and Kololo oral traditions', *Society of Malawi J.*, xxxi (1978), 9-10.

¹⁰ Kings M. Phiri, 'Chewa history in central Malawi and the use of oral tradition, 1600-1920' (Ph.D. thesis, University of Wisconsin, 1975), 24-7.

initiative in identifying his spouse, but thereafter the matter was taken up by the marriage sureties (also known as *ankhoswe*) on both sides. In addition, a token payment (in beads, chicken, iron hoes or cloth) had to be made to the bride's parents by the groom's family, and the groom had to render bride service to his parent-in-law before the marriage could be consummated. Finally, residence in the early stages of most marriages was uxorilocal. Marwick further suggested that traditionally, the marriage bond among the Chewa was very weak and could therefore be easily dissolved. He ascribed this to the absence of bridewealth, the simplicity of both marriage and divorce rituals, and the tenuous position of the son-in-law in the village community.¹¹ Women generally married quite early, within a few months of reaching puberty (i.e. between twelve and fourteen years of age). The men, however, had to wait for some time before they could marry, for they had to be capable of erecting a hut for their wife, cultivating a garden for their parents-in-law, and performing various handicrafts. Public opinion was usually against marriage by young men who had not yet acquired such skills.¹²

Uxorilocality had several implications for both wife and husband. For the wife, it apparently generated conflict between filial and conjugal loyalties, i.e. between loyalty to her own kinsmen and loyalty to her husband.¹³ For the husband, on the other hand, uxorilocality meant isolation from the base of his authority in his own matrilineal village. He could give his own family name (*mfunda*) to his children (though the latter were also free to adopt the family name of their mother's brother); he could also secure their love and respect, and the respect of the community at large, if he were generally wise and hardworking. Otherwise, he suffered from being described as a stranger in his wife's village, where he worked gardens that were not his own, begot children that did not belong to him, and was wedded to a woman who took her orders not from him but from her brother. In brief, he was, in the eyes of his wife's people, 'someone who belonged elsewhere'. To them, he was a *mkamwini* or work-horse. He could not aspire for high status no matter how influential he became in other respects. In particular, he was subject to the overriding authority of his wife's brother (the *mwini mbumba* or owner of the village), who could demand the husband's departure if his continued presence in the village became a liability.¹⁴ So invidious did the position of a uxorilocally married man appear to some writers that they saw it as a barrier to economic improvement. They argued that because a man was a 'stranger' in his wife's village, he was naturally reluctant to invest effort and money towards the improvement of the land allocated to his family. He was deterred by the fear that sooner or later he would be called upon to leave the land behind. The problem could also stem from the reluctance of the wife's

¹¹ R. S. Rattray, *Some folklore stories and songs in Chinyanja* (London, 1907), 116–18; T. Cullen Young and Hastings Banda (eds.), *Our African Way of Life* (London, 1946), 11–19, 60–94; Marwick, *Sorcery*, 169–76.

¹² Oral testimony (O.T.): Chief Mwase Lundazi and councillors to Leroy Vail and K. M. Chavura, Nthembwe village, Lundazi, 25 April 1974.

¹³ Mair, 'Marriage and family', 113.

¹⁴ M. J. Schoffeleers, *The Lower Shire Valley: its Ecology, Population Distribution, Ethnic Division and Systems of Marriage* (Limbe, 1968), 26; Marwick, *Sorcery*, 180–5; Mair, 'Marriage and family', 103; J. C. Mitchell, *The Yao Village* (Manchester, 1956), 183–5.

relatives to admit or accommodate the enterprise of someone who was considered an outsider.¹⁵

These views stretch the negative implications of uxoriolocality to their logical limits, but can hardly stand as an accurate representation of what actually happened in practice. Hard-pressed as uxorilocally married husbands undoubtedly were at times, they also had access to institutions which played an ameliorating role in their lives. One of these existed in the form of the *Nyau* secret or closed societies. These societies have tended to act as conservators of Chewa traditional values and would seem to be as old as Chewa society itself. The popular or general view is that they performed social, educational and religious functions within local Chewa society. Of late, it has been shown that for Chewa married men they served as a kind of men's club or pressure group. They enabled the men to band together, to share experiences, and to reinforce one another psychologically. As members of a *Nyau* society or brotherhood, the men would develop their own communication codes and rules and regulations of conduct. While in session, they were impervious to outside pressures. Their wives were forbidden to approach the *dambwe* or *msitu* (the secret reserve in the bush where communion was held), and they were quite free to insult and beat anyone. Under the circumstances, the uxorilocally married husband was above the ordinary law of the community, even in his dealings with his wife's parents or elders of his wife's village.¹⁶ In this way, the *Nyau* societies may have given a sense of solidarity and even considerable influence to married men in matrilineal context. Recent research has further revealed that the *Nyau* tended to act as a vehicle of resistance on other occasions as well, against forces which threatened Chewa traditional values in general and Chewa men in particular.¹⁷

The single most important hope for most Chewa men, however, lay in the possibility of exploiting institutional arrangements for ameliorating or escaping the full consequences of uxoriolocality. As Vansina has noted, uxoriolocality entails many contradictions for men in their capacity as husbands and brothers-in-law. It obviously serves their interests perfectly in the latter capacity, but as husbands they try as much as possible to avoid its full consequences. For example, they resort to cross-cousin marriages, or to marrying within their own neighbourhood, or to applying for the right to take their wives to their own homes after only a few years of uxori-local residence.¹⁸

The extent to which cross-cousin marriage was practised among the Chewa in the past is debatable, although most authorities believe that it was more common then than nowadays. For a man who opted for this kind of marriage,

¹⁵ G. T. Rimmington, 'Dedza District', *Nyasaland Journal*, xvi (1963), 38; R. W. Kettlewell, 'Agricultural change in Nyasaland, 1945-1960', *Food Research Institute Studies*, v (1965), 238-9; H. J. Lampert-Stokes, 'Land tenure in Malawi', *Society of Malawi J.*, xxiii (1970), 60-1.

¹⁶ J. Kuthemba-Mwale, 'The probable origins of the reserve: a synthesis from oral traditions' (History research paper, Chancellor College, Zomba, January 1981); M. J. Schoffeleers, 'The Nyau Societies: our present understanding', *Society of Malawi J.*, xix (1976), 59-68; A. Rita-Ferreira, 'The Nyau brotherhood among the Mozambique Chewa', *South African J. Science*, lxiv (1968), 20-1.

¹⁷ For a discussion of how Chewa men employed *Nyau* as a weapon against military recruitment in World War I, see Melvin E. Page, 'The Great War and Chewa society in Malawi', *J. Southern African Studies*, vi, ii (1980), 171-82.

¹⁸ J. Vansina, *Kingdoms of the Savanna* (Madison, 1966), 26.

the advantages were obvious. He did not go to live with his wife in a village where he was a complete stranger and, if the cousin he wished to marry was a headman's daughter, he did not have to change residence on getting married at all, for his prospective wife's village was the same as his own. The headman whose son-in-law he was would merely show him a place to build a hut for his wife.¹⁹

A more widespread practice than cross-cousin marriage was that of marrying within one's neighbourhood. The majority of Chewa men today marry within a five-kilometre radius of their own matrikin. The trend must have been even more marked in the past when population was low and most communities were separated by vast stretches of uninhabited land. This made it possible for them to visit their own kinsmen as frequently as possible, a source of psychological security when they were less than at peace in their wife's village. Indeed, Lucy Mair found that in Dedza district in the late 1940s marriages were extremely localized, with about 40 per cent of the young wives claiming to have found their husbands from their own villages, and in all about 80 per cent claiming to have secured them within a five-kilometre radius of their own villages.²⁰ A similar trend was observed by Mitchell among the Yao of southern Malawi.²¹

The arrangement which best suited most men, however, was that in which permission was granted to the husband to take the wife to his own village after a few years of uxori-local residence. This arrangement was called *chitengwa*, and it was secured by means of a mutual agreement followed by a token payment. It was readily granted where a man was appointed headman of his matrilineage or chief guardian of the women of his lineage (*mbumba*). A man could also secure *chitengwa* if it were felt that he was the only active guardian (*nkhoswe*) of his matrilineal dependants while his parents-in-law had several other sons-in-law to work for them. Occasionally, it could also be secured through pressure if a man came from a wealthy lineage in the management of whose wealth he wanted to be directly involved. The weakest ground for demanding this prerogative was where, for one reason or another, a man was simply not happy in his wife's village.²² Whatever valid reasons there were for it, the arrangement had the effect of increasing the incidence of virilocal marriages in what should have been an uxori-local context. Indeed, so widespread was this among almost all the matrilineal peoples of the Lake Malawi region that in every big village one found groups that belonged to the dominant matrilineage, as well as those which belonged to patrilocally linked lineages or lineages established by men who had married virilocally.²³

The Chewa family or lineage structure as portrayed above probably emerged out of specific economic circumstances which it in turn tended to reinforce.²⁴ As yet, however, we cannot define or describe the mode of production that may have given rise to the structure and relationships in

¹⁹ A. G. O. Hodgson, 'Notes on the Chewa and Angoni of the Dowa District of the Nyasaland Protectorate', *J.R.A.I.*, LXIII (1923), 137; Bruwer, 'Unkhoswe', 114-20.

²⁰ Mair, 'Marriage and family', 105.

²¹ Mitchell, *Yao Village*, 144, 199-201.

²² Makumbi, *Maliro ndi Miyambo*, 4-5, 20-3; Hodgson, 'Notes', 139; H. S. Stannus, 'Notes on some tribes of British Central Africa', *J.R.A.I.*, XL (1910), 308-10.

²³ For a discussion of this trend among the Yao see Mitchell, *Yao Village*, 187-97.

²⁴ See Wyatt MacGaffey, 'Lineage structure, marriage and family amongst the central Bantu', above.

question. Oral tradition indicates that there were very few durable and transferable forms of wealth in the traditional economy of the Chewa. These were for the most part confined to slaves, goats and ironware, all of which would have been important as factors of production.²⁵ The other factors were land and labour. Of the two, labour was the more important, for in oral tradition wealthy men are generally described as those who were able to control labour, usually through the ownership of large numbers of slaves or attracting dependants and clients.²⁶ Slaves were indeed an important means of production, particularly in relation to food production, livestock-keeping, ironworking and trade. Land, on the other hand, seems to have been generally plentiful, but its allocation to individual families or cultivators was one means by which a matrilineage controlled its respective families and attracted new adherents.

II

One of the changes to be dealt with in a historical study of the Chewa family system, therefore, relates to the incidence of virilocality with the passage of time. This trend may have been under way early in the nineteenth century, for an important element in this development was the growth of the slave trade through Malawi after about 1810.²⁷ The slave trade enabled matrilineages to accumulate slaves or pawns (*akapolo*) whose productive and reproductive services were then appropriated by the lineages in question. The process was similar to the one which Peel has described for nineteenth-century Yorubaland, in West Africa. There, revolution and war enabled famous warriors to accumulate wives, slaves and clients, and to use them to create great houses through which they were able to exercise influence on public affairs.²⁸

Mary Douglas has used the term 'pawn' to refer to persons who became the inheritable property of others, through slavery and related institutions. She further tried to demonstrate how the various matrilineal peoples of Central Africa would have used pawns to ensure the expansion of their lineages and to prevent the dispersal of their members.²⁹ Her suggestion is that, given a matrilineal society in which pawnship was practised, the head of a lineage who had inherited pawns could keep his male kinsmen in his village by marrying them to female pawns, while doing the same for his female dependants only as a matter of preference. The crucial element in the

²⁵ O.T.: Yohane Banda, Tiyesepo Chinguwo and Lameck Banda, Nkhako village, T. A. Chilowamatambe, Kasungu, 28 August 1973; Chintekwe Mkanthama Mwale and Kamtepa Jere, Mkanthama village, T. A. Msakambewa, Dowa, 20 March 1974.

²⁶ O.T.: Kalikokha Zimba, Lameck Chipeni, Munolo Phiri and Chibojola Banda, Nthembwe village, T. A. Kaluluma, Kasungu, 11 April 1971. See also J. van Velsen, *The Politics of Kinship: a Study in Social Manipulation among the Lakeside Tonga* (Manchester, 1964), 34–53.

²⁷ E. A. Alpers, *The East African Slave Trade* (Historical Association of Tanzania, paper no. 3: Nairobi, 1967); idem, *Ivory and Slaves*, 209–63; A. F. Isaacman, *Mozambique... the Zambezi Praios, 1750–1902* (Madison, 1972), 85–94.

²⁸ J. D. Y. Peel, 'The Changing Family in modern Ijesha history' (paper presented to the Conference on the History of the Family in Africa, School of Oriental and African Studies, London, September 1981), 5–6.

²⁹ Mary Douglas, 'Matriliny and pawnship in Central Africa', *Africa*, xxxiv (1964), 301–13.

equation, therefore, was the availability of female pawns. For the Chewa and other peoples of east-central Africa in the nineteenth century, this was not a problem at all, for most victims of the slave trade at the time were women and children anyway.³⁰ Women in particular appear to have been a special target of the slave hunters. For example, in an examination of the position of women in the Tanganyika–Nyasa corridor in the late nineteenth century, Marcia Wright notes that women there then ranked among the four most prestigious items of exchange, the others being ivory, cows and guns. She argues that this was so because, to the average home-maker, women were prospective wives, childbearers and agriculturalists.³¹

In my own study of economic change among the Chewa in the nineteenth century, I found that in the slave-oriented economic transactions of the period a greater premium was placed on female slaves of child-bearing age than on male ones. The slave dealer paid more for a prime female slave than for her male counterpart, e.g. twelve iron hoes or 24 yards of calico, as compared to ten iron hoes or 20 yards of calico.³² Children were also victims of the slave trade. Around Lake Malawi, this was because the village headmen or *ankhoswe* had the right to sell those whom they considered deviant among their female dependants and children. As one informant in southern Malawi recalled:

It was common in those days for a village headman who wanted his authority to be respected by his peers to approach one of his sisters [i.e. female dependants] and say to her, 'Look here, I don't have any guns. How can I count as a man [of authority] in the eyes of others?' Then the sister would reply to him, saying, 'Is it so? Then why don't you take this nephew of yours and see what you can do with him, for he never listens to me; he is too naughty.'³³

With female slaves or pawns acquired through either slave trading or some legal procedure, it was possible for the Chewa matrilineage to expand and at the same time make uxori-local marriage optional for some of its male members. As elsewhere in the matrilineal belt of Central Africa, the practice of slavery or pawnship gave certain men access to persons over whom they were able to exercise direct control.³⁴ Among the Chewa, it would seem that only headmen, entrepreneurs and successful craftsmen were able to acquire slaves or pawns. Within each matrilineage, however, overall control over such slaves was vested in the lineage head. Secondly, the practice of marrying female slaves to male members of the matrilineage was widespread. It was

³⁰ This is clearly brought out in Megan A. Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in Southern Malawi: a study of rural communities in the Shire Highlands and Upper Shire Valley from 1850 to 1915' (Ph.D. thesis, University of London, 1981), 38–50.

³¹ Marcia Wright, 'Women in peril: a commentary on the life stories of captives in 19th century east-central Africa', *African Social Research*, xx (1975), 800–19.

³² Kings M. Phiri, 'Pre-colonial economic change in Central Malawi: the development and expansion of trade systems', *Malawi J. Social Science*, v (1976), 19.

³³ O. T.: Andrew Likambale to Kings Phiri and Gaudensio Maluza, Makanjila village, T. A. Chikowi, Zomba, 21 July 1980.

³⁴ For a recent overview of the implications of Mary Douglas' thesis, see Thomas Q. Reeve, 'The Eastern Savanna and Northern Zambezia to the 1890s' (paper presented to the Conference on the Social, Political and Economic History of Central Africa, University of Kent, Canterbury, 7–11 July 1980), 1–12.

a means by which men were able to build up independent families, thereby overcoming the liability, under matrilineal usage, of having limited control over their offspring. In any case, female slaves were married virilocally since they were persons without guardians (*ankhoswe*). Thirdly, as a consequence of slave marriage, headmen or heads of matrilineages were able to avoid the dispersal of their male kinsmen by offering them slave wives or concubines.³⁵

So widespread, apparently, was the institution of slave marriage among the Chewa in the nineteenth century that early in this century Chewa elders still spoke nostalgically about it. They maintained that women who had been captured in war or purchased from slave caravans made better wives than those married under regular matrilineal custom. They were the property of the husband, tended to abide with him permanently, and did their utmost to secure his favour. For this reason, a man who had both free and slave wives often gave greater attention to the latter than the former.³⁶ Further proof regarding the popularity of slave marriage in the past comes from the fact that the Chewa and their neighbours did not in any way discriminate against the offspring of slave wives. For example, in the Yao chiefly line of Mponda at the southern end of the lake in 1888–9, Mkwate, the son of one of Mponda I's slave wives, became a serious contender for the throne following his father's death. It is reported that for a brief period he even forced his cousin and the legitimate heir, Ngale, to abdicate in his favour.³⁷

III

Matriliny among the Chewa in the nineteenth century also changed through their interaction with the various patrilineal groups which then migrated into their country. These included the Chikunda from the Zambezi *prazos* in the south, the Ngoni from southern Africa, and Swahili from the east coast of Africa. The Ngoni in particular greatly influenced Chewa social structure.

As Reece has argued, the various invaders of central and eastern Africa in the nineteenth century were affected by the cultures they touched, and in turn imparted some of their own cultural characteristics to the peoples they conquered.³⁸ With special reference to the lower Shire valley in southern Malawi, Schoffeleers has shown how the immigration, since about 1860, of patrilineal peoples, e.g. Kololo, Sena, Chikunda, Phodzo and Zimba, had so altered Mang'anja social organization that the Mang'anja are now divided into those who still maintain the original matrilineal organization and those who have become patrilineal as a result of foreign influence.³⁹ Similarly, in the upper Shire Valley where Nyanja and Yao have interacted with Ngoni and Kololo since the 1870s, Kandawire has noted that a considerable

³⁵ Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 32–5; Vaughan, 'Social and economic change in southern Malawi', 39–40; Mitchell, *The Yao Village*, 195–7.

³⁶ S. S. Murray, *A Handbook of Nyasaland* (Zomba, 1922), 52–3.

³⁷ Dennis F. Namate, 'The emergence of the Yao as a political and economic force in Mangochi district: the case of Mponda's area, 1810–1910' (History student research paper, Chancellor College, Zomba, February 1981).

³⁸ Reece, 'The Eastern Savanna and Northern Zambezia', 38.

³⁹ Schoffeleers, *Lower Shire Valley*, 110–25.

interlacing of matrilineal and patrilineal principles of social organization has occurred.⁴⁰

Of the patrilineal groups which settled among the Chewa in the nineteenth century, the Chikunda were the first to arrive, coming as early as the 1870s. They came in small bands as elephant hunters, ivory traders and refugees from their Portuguese overlords on the Zambezi *prazos* and settled in widely scattered spots. Although originally patrilineal in their social organization, with the passage of time they tended to be absorbed into the mainstream of Chewa cultural life.⁴¹

Muslim Swahili traders from the east coast of Africa settled at Nkhota-Kota midway along the western coast of Lake Malawi in the 1840s. Under the leadership of Salim bin Abdallah, also known as the Jumbe, they established their hegemony over the indigenous Chewa groups, intermarried with them, and gathered large numbers of Chewa refugees around their settlement. They practised virilocal plural marriages with their female clients.⁴²

The patrilineal and pastoral Ngoni, as is well known, entered the Lake Malawi region in the mid nineteenth century, after trekking from Zululand in southeast Africa where they fled from Shaka. By 1870 three branches of Ngoni had settled permanently among or near the Chewa of Central Malawi, in Dowa, Dedza and Mchinji districts.⁴³ Using the policy of assimilation which they evolved during their migration from the south, and the strength of their military organization, they gathered many of the defeated Chewa inhabitants around them. In the Ngoni polities, the Chewa became a subject people (*abafu*) who were compelled to fight and work for their Ngoni masters. In the process they adopted Ngoni fighting techniques, dances and mode of dress. They also intermarried with the Ngoni as time went on.⁴⁴

In the view of many writers, although the Ngoni retained their political and military dominance, their culture increasingly bore the imprint of Chewa institutions. In particular, it is maintained that Chewa family structure thrived even inside the Ngoni states. Uxorilocal marriage coupled with matrilineal descent and property inheritance rules were adopted by the Ngoni themselves.⁴⁵ Those who settled in Ntchisi and Dowa districts under Chiwere

⁴⁰ J. A. K. Kandawire, *Thangata: Forced Labour or Reciprocal Assistance?* (Blantyre, 1979), 143.

⁴¹ Phiri, 'Pre-colonial economic change in central Malawi', 20-1 → A. F. Isaacman, 'The origin, formation and early history of the Chikunda of south-central Africa', *J. Afr. Hist.*, XIII (1972), 452-71.

⁴² H. W. Langworthy, 'Swahili influence in the area between Lake Malawi and the Luangwa valley', *Int. J. African Historical Studies*, IV (1971), 583-91; Phiri, 'Chewa history', 137-45.

⁴³ T. T. Spear, 'Zwangendaba's Ngoni, 1821-1890: a political and social history of a migration' (University of Wisconsin; African Studies Program, occasional paper: 1972); M. Read, *The Ngoni of Nyasaland* (London, 1956), 10-14; J. A. Barnes, *Politics in a Changing Society: a Political History of the Fort Jameson Ngoni* (Cape Town, 1954), 1-35; B. Pachai, 'Ngoni politics and diplomacy in Malawi, 1848-1904', in idem (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi* (London, 1972), 179-214; Ian Linden, 'The Maseko Ngoni at Domwe, 1870-1900' *ibid.* 237-50; J. T. Thompson, 'The origins, migration and settlement of the northern Ngoni', *Society of Malawi J.*, xxxiv (1980), 6-28.

⁴⁴ Hodgson, 'Notes', 128-9; Phiri, 'Chewa history', 145-65.

⁴⁵ H. W. Langworthy, 'Central Malawi in the 19th century', in R. J. Macdonald (ed.), *From Nyasaland to Malawi* (Nairobi, 1975), 20-1.

and Msakambewa apparently went even further than this. They adopted not only the matrilineal system of descent and the Chichewa language, but also such prominent Chewa cultural institutions as *mzinda* (village initiation rights) and the *Nyau* secret societies.⁴⁶

Others have been more cautious in their assessment of Chewa influence on the Ngoni. They argue that it was a long time before the Chewa were able to assert their cultural identity vis-à-vis their Ngoni overlords. In their view, it was the decline of the Ngoni military tradition under the *Pax Britannica* that led to a renaissance of Chewa culture, a process which was enhanced by the numerical superiority of the Chewa over the Ngoni.⁴⁷ The suggestion, then, is that initially it was the Ngoni who were successful in stamping their own social system – including virilocal marriage and patrilineal descent – on the Chewa. This is borne out by a number of witnesses. At the beginning of this century, Rattray, a missionary who served among the Chewa of Dowa and Ntchisi, found that wherever a number of Ngoni immigrants had settled, both Chewa and Ngoni practised a dual system of marriage. One was uxorilocal, the other virilocal. The latter involved the transfer of considerable wealth (usually goats) from the husband's lineage to that of the wife, and was therefore referred to as 'marriage by purchase'. Under this kind of marriage contract, the wife invariably went to live at the husband's village.⁴⁸ Hodgson witnessed a similar situation among the Chewa of Dowa district in the 1920s. He found that some had intermixed with the Ngoni so much that they followed the Ngoni custom of paying *lobola* (bridewealth) and having the wife transferred to the husband's village.⁴⁹

IV

Missionary work too has had its impact on the Chewa family system. This began in 1876 when Scottish Presbyterian missionaries settled on the south-western coast of Lake Malawi. They were joined by Dutch Reformed Church missionaries from South Africa who began work at Mvela in Dowa district in 1889. They in turn were followed by the Universities Mission to Central Africa (Anglican) which opened a station at Nkhota-kota in 1895. Finally, the Catholics settled among the Maseko Ngoni in Ntcheu district in 1901. By 1910, many parts of Chewa country had been brought under some Christian impact, primarily because the various missionary societies operated in a competitive spirit.⁵⁰

Until the First World War, however, these missions made very little progress in their effort to evangelize the Chewa. According to Stuart, this was because in being interested in men's souls, as opposed to political power, the missionaries posed a more serious threat to Chewa traditional values than,

⁴⁶ Mair, 'Marriage and family', 104; Hodgson, 'Notes', 106; Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 162–3.

⁴⁷ G. T. Rimmington, 'The historical geography of population growth in the Dedza District of Nyasaland', *Nyasaland J.*, xvi (1963), 47–9.

⁴⁸ Rattray, *Some folk stories*, 112–16.

⁴⁹ Hodgson, 'Notes', 138.

⁵⁰ K. J. McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi, 1875–1940* (Cambridge, 1977), 180–4; Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 112–84; Ian Linden, *Catholics, Peasants and Chewa Resistance in Nyasaland, 1889–1939* (London, 1974), 42–86.

say, the colonial administration which came after them. A more basic explanation than this, however, is that in calling for the young men whom they were anxious to educate and socialize, the missionaries automatically came into conflict with Chewa village initiation schools or societies in the form of *cinamwali* and the *Nyau*. It is not surprising, therefore, that opposition to the missionaries came from the headmen or senior *ankhoswe* and those who were responsible for the initiation ceremonies (the *anamkungwi* and *akunjira*). In Ntchisi district, for example, these saw the U.M.C.A. missionaries and schoolteachers as a real threat to traditional Chewa values and rituals.⁵¹ The problem was compounded by the missionaries themselves, most of whom adopted a stern and uncompromising attitude towards certain Chewa rituals, such as the initiation rites for girls. It took the missionaries a long time to realize that institutions like *cinamwali*, through which Chewa girls were prepared for their role as future mothers, were useful and worth adapting in the context of the church. In particular, they came to appreciate the importance of these rites in offering sex education, emphasizing the spiritual aspects of fertility, instruction in correct social behaviour, respect for the elders and authority, and the need for endurance of physical hardship.⁵² In doing so, the missionaries in Malawi fell in line with what had already become common practice among their counterparts elsewhere in Africa. For example, on the Witwatersrand by the 1930s and 1940s, Protestant missionaries had expanded their terms of reference to include the provision of substitute initiation and sex education for Christian girls. Special schools on the traditional model were organized in which anatomy and physiology, facts about sex and birth, and the care of children were all covered.⁵³

Besides initiation rites, there were many other areas in which Christian teaching as presented by the missionaries came into conflict with certain matrilineal family notions. They included that of the relationship between husband and wife, responsibility for children, polygamy, and divorce. All the missionaries (Dutch Reformed Church, Anglican and Presbyterian) stuck to the Pauline view that the husband is head of the nuclear family unit and that this authority, therefore, had to precede that of the wife or wife's guardian. They also laid emphasis on parental control of and responsibility for the children. If taken seriously, such teachings would obviously have undermined the avunculate. As Stuart has argued, for the Chewa the acceptance of Christian teachings on marriage would have entailed rejecting certain fundamental matrilineal principles, diminished the status of the *ankhoswe*, and in some respects jeopardized the women's social security.⁵⁴ Elsewhere in Central Africa, Christian missionaries exerted tremendous pressures on African marriage and family systems, particularly in areas where they were most active. The Catholic missionaries who settled at Chishawasha near Harare (Salisbury) in Zimbabwe, for example, interfered with some traditional marriage customs, e.g. polygamy and remarriage of widows, but at the same

⁵¹ Page, 'The Great War and Chewa Society', 173; Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 167–84; Phiri, 'Chewa history in Central Malawi', 181–3.

⁵² Pauline Pretorius, 'An attempt at Christian initiation in Nyasaland', *Int. Rev. Missions*, 1 (1950), 284–91.

⁵³ Deborah Gaitskell, 'Housewives, maids or mothers', above.

⁵⁴ Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 78–9, 197–224.

time perpetuated and reinforced others, e.g. *lobola* (the payment of bridewealth).⁵⁵

Although, with the passage of time, the missionaries acquired a remarkable understanding of Chewa society, their teachings as well as practical results of their work came to have a negative impact on matriliney in two ways. One was that from the 1920s onwards both the D.R.C.M. and U.M.C.A. experimented with Christian initiation schools which virtually replaced the traditional initiation ceremonies as far as Christian families were concerned. Their teaching also underlined the need for the husband's authority over and responsibility for his wife and children. It also led to a redefinition of marriage. Instead of viewing marriage as a contract between two families or lineages, the girls were made to view it as a contract between husband and wife on the one side and God on the other.⁵⁶ In addition, however, within a few decades of their settlement in the country, the missionaries began to turn out educated teachers and evangelists for their own employ, and policemen, clerks, messengers, foremen and watchmen for government service. These men were usually posted far from home and took their wives with them. In this situation, the husband's authority over and responsibility for his wife and children was enhanced and the wives learned to do without the support of their *ankhoswe*.⁵⁷

Lastly, the Chewa family system has been greatly affected by modern socio-economic changes and in particular by colonialism and the development of a capitalist economy. Much of central Malawi came under British colonial rule between 1893 and 1897. Harry Johnston, the first British Consul and Commissioner-General in the region, employed either diplomacy or force to compel Chewa rulers and their followers to surrender their authority and sovereignty. The effects which the introduction of colonial rule had on the political and economic structures of the various Malawian peoples have already been the subject of detailed studies.⁵⁸ Of special significance as far as the family was concerned were the introduction of a cash economy, the creation of a labour market, and the imposition of hut or poll tax. These altered relations within the family and the pattern of family life generally in several fundamental ways.

Hut-tax collection in particular introduced a level of violence and insecurity in Chewa domestic life which rivalled that at the height of the slave trade in the later nineteenth century. When Johnston introduced the hut tax in 1893 and when his successor, Alfred Sharpe, revised it upwards in 1901, it was with the explicit intention of testing the loyalty of the chiefs (whose overall support the new administration required) and compelling Africans to work on European estates in the Shire Highlands and to serve as porters for

⁵⁵ Mary Aquina, 'A note on missionary influence on Shona marriage', *Rhodes-Livingstone J.*, xxxiii (1963), 68-78.

⁵⁶ The full implications of Christian teaching on marriage and the family are discussed at length in Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 26-63.

⁵⁷ Pretorius, 'An attempt at Christian initiation', 286.

⁵⁸ Roland Oliver, *Sir Harry Johnston and the Scramble for Africa* (London, 1956), 197-271; Eric Stokes, 'Malawi political systems and the introduction of colonial rule, 1891-1896', in E. Stokes and R. Brown (eds.), *The Zambesian Past* (Manchester, 1965), 352-75; D. S. Sankhani, 'The British Occupation of Malawi: the military odds, 1850-1900' (History student research paper, Chancellor College, Zomba, 1972).

European commercial firms. In this way, it was hoped that Africans would make a worthwhile contribution to the development of the colonial economy.⁵⁹ The social consequences of the enforcement measures that would be involved were not foreseen. Men and women were often seized and taken to the *boma* (government central station) as hostages for failing to pay their tax, while in matrilineal areas husbands who could not pay tax for their wives and even for their parents-in-law became objects of ridicule. This sometimes strained their marriages.⁶⁰

As the colonial government extended its influence into the countryside, men increasingly came under the coercive power of its local agencies, sometimes with disturbing consequences for their family life. For example, the government often recruited men for public works projects such as road-building or for work on European plantations, or occasionally for outside mining and agricultural concerns such as those in Southern Rhodesia (now Zimbabwe). All these measures had the effect of taking the men to places of work outside their normal social boundaries. Here, they acquired or were influenced by new experiences and value systems. All this happened while the position and status of their wives remained rather fossilized within the context of Chewa village life.⁶¹ As time went on, this undoubtedly created a discrepancy between the self-perception of men and women as well as in the degree of their commitment to matriliney.

In most parts of Africa, colonialism and capitalism developed hand-in-hand, although one can also speak of the colonial flag as having followed commerce, as in Malawi. In general, the intrusion of capitalism with its world-wide ramifications created new economic opportunities for local peoples but at the same time called for the restructuring of old social relationships. In her studies of family and kinship among the Akan of Ghana, Christine Oppong has highlighted a number of revolutionary changes which followed their entry into a 'unitary market system' involving trade with coastal merchants and cocoa cash-cropping. The capitalist pattern of development influenced residential patterns, property-holding, and patterns of inheritance. In particular, it adversely affected matrilineal relationships, since the new developments favoured those who were prepared to work for the welfare of their own conjugal families.⁶²

When we turn to the growth of a capitalist economy among the Chewa, however, our concern is primarily with labour issues, for production for the market was very slow to emerge in central Malawi, and as early as the 1890s the area was being turned into a labour market for European enterprises elsewhere. Peasant production with its linkages to the world capitalist economy did not have an impact on the Chewa until thirty years later. It began through the introduction, by European planters, of fire-cured tobacco grown by African tenants in Lilongwe and Dowa districts. The government first

⁵⁹ C. A. Cardew, 'Nyasaland in 1894-1895', *Nyasaland J.*, 1 (1948), 54; G. S. Mwase (ed. R. I. Rotberg), *Strike a Blow and Die* (Cambridge, Mass., 1967), 61.

⁶⁰ E. Smith, *Report on Direct Taxation in Nyasaland* (Zomba, 1937); C. Baker, 'Tax collection in Malawi: an administrative history', *Int. J. Afr. Hist. Studies*, VIII (1975), 40-62; Kandawire, *Thangata*, 27-9.

⁶¹ Stuart, 'Christianity and the Chewa', 194-6.

⁶² Christine Oppong, *Marriage among a Matrilineal elite: a Family Study of Ghanaian Senior Civil Servants* (Cambridge, 1974), 34-48.

became involved in 1926 when it created a Native Tobacco Board to organize production and marketing, and later on in 1943 when it passed the Marketing of Native Produce Ordinance under which private buyers were licensed to purchase rice, maize and groundnuts from the peasant producers.⁶³

Chewa households appear to have been particularly responsive to the existence of opportunities for growing tobacco. In Dowa and Lilongwe districts, where conditions were suited for this, the number of growers stood at 32,000 in 1928, 50,000 in 1945 and 60,000 in 1960. However, the production of cash crops as opposed to food crops was almost entirely in the hands of the men. For those of them who were married uxorilocally, the investment of effort on cash as opposed to subsistence crop production was probably a source of conflict between them and their wives' parents or guardians. This, however, is a point that needs further investigation.

The single most pervasive consequence of the growth of a capitalist economy, however, was that it induced labour emigration. Several factors in the 1890s and first decade of this century led to labour emigration for virtually all the rural parts of the country. The introduction of hut tax was one of them. Government pressure, necessitated by the need to satisfy the labour demands of under-capitalized European enterprises within the country as well as outside, was another. Yet others included the desire to satisfy needs stimulated by the modern cash economy, and the social prestige enjoyed by those who had travelled and seen foreign lands.⁶⁴

The Chewa and Ngoni from central Malawi first began to migrate to the plantations of the Shire Highlands in southern Malawi around 1894. After 1903, some of them began to make the longer trip to the mines and plantations of the Zimbabwean highveld and the Transvaal. From then onwards, labour migration became the most persistent experience of the Chewa and other rural peoples of Malawi.⁶⁵ Among them, this movement of the men in and out of their communities and their exposure to the wider environment of wage labour and urban industry was bound to affect adversely the structure and functioning of the family. In the 1930s, for example, considerable attention in Malawi was drawn to the effects of labour migration on family life. It was noted that in the absence of their husbands, the young wives suffered from lack of economic and emotional security, that children grew up without adequate parental control, that marital infidelity increased, leading to the dissolution of many a marriage, and that the agricultural productivity of the household went into decline.⁶⁶

Perhaps the best analysis of the impact of labour migration on the matrilineal family was that offered by Margaret Read. She observed that labour migration militated against both marital stability and uxorilocality.

⁶³ Kettlewell, 'Agricultural change' (cited in n. 15), 237-68; M. L. Chanock, 'Notes on an agricultural history of Malawi', in M. E. Page (ed.), *Land and Labour in Rural Malawi* (East Lansing, 1973), 27-37.

⁶⁴ Leroy Vail, 'The political economy of colonialism in Northern Zambezia, 1890-1975' (paper presented to the Conference on the Social, Political and Economic History of Central Africa, University of Kent, Canterbury, 7-11 July 1980); see also J. C. Mitchell, 'The causes of labour migration', *Inter-African Labour Institute Bulletin*, vi (1959), 14-47.

⁶⁵ R. B. Boeder, 'Malawians abroad: the history of labour emigration from Malawi to its neighbours, 1890 to the present' (Ph.D. thesis, Michigan State University, 1974), 1-194; Murray, *Handbook*, 45.

⁶⁶ For a summary, see Boeder, 'Malawians abroad', 195-212.

The absence of the husband for two or more years deprived the wife's parents of his valuable labour services, notwithstanding the goods he brought back. During the husband's absence, roles tended to be reversed in that the wife was then looked after by her parents, whereas they would ordinarily have been looked after by their daughter and her husband. To make matters worse, upon his return the husband rarely gave his parents-in-law an adequate share of his purchases since he had to offer some of them to his own kinsmen. All this created strains and stresses which some marriages never survived.⁶⁷ Read further noted that when they were about to migrate the men were likely to seek the transfer of their wives to their own matrilineages, since it was generally felt that this was the safest way of ensuring the wife's fidelity while her husband was away. Secondly, most migrants feared that their wives and children would become overdependent on their matrikin in the husband's absence. The men feared having to pay a high price for this upon their return. In support of this general thesis, Marwick found that in eastern Zambia a number of Chewa men who had just returned from wage-earning occupations outside Chewa country were anxious to work for the welfare of their own nuclear families (wife and children), rather than for the wife's kinsmen as such. To avoid the latter, they sought all possible arrangements for making their marriages virilocal.⁶⁸

Labour migration from rural Malawi has also been related to urbanization within Malawi, even though this has been less marked than in neighbouring Zambia and Zimbabwe. The commercial and industrial growth of Blantyre in the south and to some extent of Lilongwe in the Chewa heartland, particularly after about 1935, has, as elsewhere in Africa, led to a minor rural-urban drift. Already a small percentage of those involved had become urbanized by 1950. Among them, as Hastings has noted, the wide-range matrilineal family has had to give way to a narrow-range patrilineal one. This is because it is the women who follow their husbands to these distant, urban centres of wage employment. The ultimate result is that small nuclear families are created in which the husband has full control over both wife and children. The husband is, in other words, 'able to enjoy both uxorilocal and genetricial rights',⁶⁹ a far cry from what his position would be in the traditional, matrilineal setting.

CONCLUSION

At present, it is not possible fully to document the changes which have taken place in Chewa matrilineality since the mid nineteenth century. The problem is further complicated by the fact that none of the changes I have tried to chart in this paper occurred throughout Chewa society at any given time. Some, like those which were rooted in the practice of slavery in the nineteenth century, probably affected the greater part of it. Others, such as those associated with Christian missionary activity, were probably confined to pockets that were widely distributed but isolated from each other. There is

⁶⁷ M. Read, 'Migrant labour in Africa and its effects on tribal life', *Int. Labour Review*, XLV, vi, (1942), 624-8.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.* 628-9; Marwick, *Sorcery*, 97.

⁶⁹ Adrian Hastings, *Christian Marriage in Africa* (London, 1973), 41.

also the problem of trying to generalize about a society that was increasingly becoming stratified and differentiated. Nevertheless, it is perhaps worth commenting briefly on what seem to be the consequences of at least some of the changes that have been noted above.

One view is that forces such as the intrusion of patrilineal peoples, Christian missionary activity, colonialism and the modern capitalist economy, have so transformed the matrilineage with its various segments that it no longer exists as a functional unit. This is the conclusion reached by Kandawire after his intensive study of the Nyanja (Chewa) and Yao of the upper Shire. He concludes that by the 1960s the matrilineage and its major segments there had ceased to exist as viable social or economic units. Instead, the basic unit of production and consumption was the nuclear family comprising husband, wife and children. He ascribed this development to modern pressures such as missionary education, the drift to urban centres, the growth of a cash economy with its emphasis on individualism, and overpopulation relative to the amount of available arable land.⁷⁰ This is a radical departure from the ideal matrilineal situation portrayed at the beginning of this paper. It is doubtful that the Chewa in rural parts of central Malawi have experienced such a radical transformation of their social structure. What appears to have happened among them is that certain matrilineal principles which are incompatible with modern changes have simply been waived. In a number of cases these include uxori-locality and its corollary, the avunculate.

Uxori-locality in particular has diminished, because of its incompatibility with modernization and economic change. For example, men engaged in cash-crop production would like to have access to as much arable land as possible. Yet this is virtually impossible where they are married uxori-locally. Uxori-locality is also strained where men are geographically mobile due to their having to go out to look for wage employment or other economic opportunities.⁷¹

Scarcely anywhere among the Chewa in central Malawi today does the mother's brother exercise the kind of domestic authority he may once have had; the father has assumed that role. As Oppong has noted for the Akan, this is because the role of guardian of a child has changed. It is no longer a matter of simple upkeep, but one that requires active improvement of the child's condition, through proper training in school to fit the child for new positions in the expanding economy.⁷² Among the Chewa, this not only involves sending the child to school and buying him relatively expensive clothes, but also financing his first trip to urban centres where he will later on go to look for wage employment. These are obligations which the father somehow fulfils more readily and willingly than the maternal uncle. The result is that the father's influence has grown correspondingly.⁷³

⁷⁰ Kandawire, *Thangata*, 96–7.

⁷¹ Paul Kishindo, 'Matrilineality and agricultural change in Malawi' (research proposal, Department of Sociology, University of Hull, March 1981).

⁷² Oppong, *Marriage*, 47.

⁷³ Mair, 'Marriage and family', 119.

SUMMARY

In its ideal form, the Chewa family system is supposed to place considerable emphasis on the mother right, the avunculate, uxori-local marriage, husband's subordination to wife's kin, and importance of female children as future reproducers of the lineage. In practice, however, there are a number of factors which have tended to mitigate the impact of these tendencies in the system, as far as men or husbands are concerned. Attention has been drawn to the fact that a number of important changes in the marriage contract, family residential patterns, exercise of domestic authority, and control or custody of children, have been the result of historical developments. There is therefore a need to understand these developments, even if the changes in the Chewa family system to which they led have not brought about a complete transformation of the system.

Several of these historical developments have been reviewed, as well as the features of patriliney to which they have given rise in several parts of central Malawi. They include the growth of the slave trade in the nineteenth century and the opportunity which this gave to some lineages to acquire women who could be married virilocally; the intrusion of patrilineal peoples like the Ngoni which increased the incidence of virilocal marriage and patrilineal descent; the spread of certain Christian missionary teachings that are in conflict with matrilineal principles of family organisation; and such developments of the colonial period as labour migrancy and cash-cropping which often impinged on relations between husband and wife and family life in general.